

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Restaurant Serving English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Restaurant servers, food runners, and dining-room service staff.

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Confirming seats and order details

Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order.

02 Explaining menu choices and prices

Compare complete menu options without hiding an extra charge.

03 Receiving an allergy question

Acknowledge a stated allergy and identify the information still needed.

04 Coordinating courses and delays

Report an actual delay while keeping approximate timing clear.

05 Correcting a dish without blame

Acknowledge a specific mismatch and agree what happens next.

06 Explaining and splitting a bill

Distinguish equal payment shares from item-based bills.

07 Agreeing on clearing and shared service

Get permission to clear specific items without rushing the table.

08 Handing over a live section

Name each table's status and get the incoming server's acknowledgment.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Confirming seats and order details

Clarify an ambiguous modifier and confirm the complete order.

CASE

Table 12 has three covers. Seat one orders mushroom pasta, seat two orders a salad with dressing separately, and seat three has not chosen. The phrase 'no onions' was spoken without a clear seat reference. Clarify before sending the order.

Teach this move

A modifier needs a dish and a diner. 'On the side' means separately, not omitted. Ask a focused question before reading back the order.

Vocabulary to check: cover, seat number, modifier, read-back.

Model response

Before I send table twelve's order, could I check who requested no onions? I have mushroom pasta for seat one and a salad with dressing on the side for seat two. Seat three is still deciding. I'll attach the onion request to the correct dish and read those details back.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised order identifies the diner and both changes.

Second-round challenge

Seat one also wants dressing for a side salad. Keep that request separate from seat two's main salad.

Language-check answers

1. D - on the side Correct. The dressing arrives in a separate serving.
2. D - which seat you are sitting in Correct. The embedded question keeps the subject before its verb.

05 • Conversations

1. Whose onion request? - Table 12: the three-cover order in the case.
2. Moving chairs after ordering - Two diners have swapped seats before a runner arrives.
3. A phrase lost in the noise - A server checks an incomplete order during a busy lunch.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two similar side dishes

A table orders one baked potato and one portion of mashed potatoes. The server hears 'without butter' but cannot identify the dish.

Role A: Server: clarify the dish and repeat both side orders.

Role B: Guest: the baked potato is yours and you prefer it without butter; the mashed potatoes belong to your companion.

Possible opening: Was the no-butter request for the baked potato or the mashed potatoes?

Success checks

- Obtain the dish name.
- Attach the preference to the baked potato only.
- Read back both orders without inventing an ingredient claim.

Add a complication: The guest points instead of naming the dish, and both diners are holding menus.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining menu choices and prices

Compare complete menu options without hiding an extra charge.

CASE

The fictional lunch set costs \$24 and includes a main and dessert. Steak adds a \$5 supplement. The a la carte steak is \$27 without dessert. Both steak options include potatoes. Explain the \$29 set steak option versus \$27 steak alone.

Teach this move

Name the base price, any supplement, and what comes with each option. 'Whereas' introduces a contrast; it does not explain a cause.

Vocabulary to check: a la carte, set menu, supplement, side dish.

Model response

The steak set would be twenty-nine dollars: the twenty-four-dollar set price plus a five-dollar supplement. It includes dessert and potatoes. The a la carte steak is twenty-seven dollars with potatoes but no dessert. If you don't want dessert, the separate steak costs less; the set includes the extra course.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. A supplement is an addition, not the whole price.

Second-round challenge

The guest says 'So both are twenty-four dollars?' Correct the total without restarting the whole menu explanation.

Language-check answers

1. A - added to Correct. The supplement increases the base price.
2. A - whereas Correct. This contrasts the included items.

05 • Conversations

1. The five-dollar misunderstanding - The lunch menu in the case is open between server and guest.
2. A starter is not a side - A diner compares a side salad with a larger starter salad.
3. Today's special has a price - A server describes a special before the diner commits.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A shared starter charge

A fictional menu lists a soup starter at \$7 and a sharing platter at \$18. The platter description says 'serves two'; \$18 is the whole platter price.

Role A: Server: explain price and suggested serving size.

Role B: Guest: ask whether 'serves two' means \$18 per person; choose the platter once clarified.

Possible opening: Is the sharing platter eighteen dollars each?

Success checks

- State that \$18 covers one platter.
- Separate serving size from a per-person price.
- Confirm whether the guest wants additional soup.

Add a complication: The guest also assumes two soups are included, but neither is included.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Receiving an allergy question

Acknowledge a stated allergy and identify the information still needed.

CASE

A guest at table 6 reports a sesame allergy and asks about a bun. The server has an old menu description, not current ingredient or cross-contact information. The kitchen lead is available to discuss the question before any order is sent.

Teach this move

A menu description may omit ingredients. 'Not listed' differs from 'not present.' Keep ingredient information separate from cross-contact questions.

Vocabulary to check: allergen, cross-contact, ingredient list, dietary preference.

Model response

Thank you for telling me about your sesame allergy. The old menu description doesn't establish the current bun's ingredients or how it is handled. I can't confirm suitability from that description. I'll ask the kitchen lead to check your specific question before sending a food order, and bring back the verified information.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. Absence from a short description is not evidence of suitability.

Second-round challenge

The guest says they ate the bun last month. Explain why the current item still needs checking.

Language-check answers

1. A - not listed here Correct. This limits the claim to the visible description.
2. B - allergy Correct. The singular noun follows 'an'.

05 • Conversations

1. The bun description is incomplete - Table 6: the sesame question from the case.
2. An omission isn't an allergy label - A diner requests no coriander for taste, and the server checks meaning.
3. Repeating the guest's actual words - A server speaks to the kitchen lead about a pending order.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A changed sauce supplier

A diner reports a peanut allergy. A colleague remembers an earlier sauce specification, but this week's sauce comes from a different supplier.

Role A: Server: explain the limit of the old information and request a current check.

Role B: Kitchen lead: you can review the new product information and speak to the diner; suitability is not yet established.

Possible opening: Does last week's ingredient sheet apply to this week's sauce?

Success checks

- Identify the supplier mismatch.
- Keep the food choice pending.
- Relay the allergy rather than infer a preference.

Add a complication: The old sheet has the same product name but a different supplier.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Coordinating courses and delays

Report an actual delay while keeping approximate timing clear.

CASE

Table 14 finished starters. Their mains were fired at 7:20. At 7:30 the kitchen estimates another eight minutes; one dish is still being prepared. The guests need to leave at 7:50. State the estimate and offer a timing discussion without guaranteeing completion.

Teach this move

Say when the estimate was obtained and whether it means additional time. Do not confuse 'held' with 'canceled' or 'being prepared' with 'ready'.

Vocabulary to check: course, fire, hold, estimated wait.

Model response

We asked the kitchen to start your mains at seven twenty. One dish is still being prepared, and the current estimate is another eight minutes. I know you need to leave at seven fifty. That is an estimate, not a guaranteed serving time; would you like me to discuss your timing with the kitchen?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised update gives usable timing without pretending certainty.

Second-round challenge

The estimate changes to twelve more minutes. Report the change and ask whether the guest wants available alternatives discussed.

Language-check answers

1. A - additional Correct. Additional means more time beyond what has passed.
2. A - not canceled Correct. Holding postpones the course without canceling its order.

05 • Conversations

1. Eight more minutes - Table 14 at 7:30, following the timing case.
2. Holding dessert for a call - A diner requests a pause between the main and dessert.

3. One plate isn't the whole table - A runner checks an incomplete pickup at the pass.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Starter or main?

A guest orders soup and pasta and says 'together.' The restaurant normally serves starters before mains; neither item has been sent.

Role A: Server: check whether both dishes should arrive at once.

Role B: Guest: you want soup as your main while your companion eats pasta, not two courses for yourself.

Possible opening: When you say together, are these two mains for different people?

Success checks

- Clarify diners and timing.
- Correct the seat assignment.
- Read back simultaneous service as a request, not a guaranteed time.

Add a complication: The order screen currently assigns both dishes to one seat.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Correcting a dish without blame

Acknowledge a specific mismatch and agree what happens next.

CASE

Table 3 ordered vegetable pasta but received mushroom risotto. The ticket confirms pasta. The kitchen offers a pasta remake with an estimated ten-minute wait. The server may offer that replacement, but any bill adjustment needs the shift lead's review.

Teach this move

A useful apology names the error. Give the available option and its wait before asking for a choice; a replacement isn't automatically a refund.

Vocabulary to check: remake, replacement, check-back, service recovery.

Model response

I'm sorry we brought risotto when your order was vegetable pasta. I've checked the ticket, and it does show pasta. The kitchen can remake it, with an estimated ten-minute wait. Would that work for you? If you want to discuss a bill adjustment, I'll ask our shift lead rather than promise one myself.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The correction addresses the guest's experience without shifting blame.

Second-round challenge

The guest declines a replacement. Accept the choice and bring the shift lead into the bill discussion.

Language-check answers

1. D - we brought Correct. Past tense acknowledges what happened.
2. D - a newly prepared replacement dish Correct. The kitchen prepares a fresh replacement for the dish.

05 • Conversations

1. Risotto instead of pasta - Table 3 receives the wrong main, as in the case.
2. A check-back gets a real answer - A guest says a meal is not what they expected.
3. Two plates crossed at pickup - A runner discovers that two complete orders were assigned to wrong tables.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The sauce arrived on the food

A guest requested sauce separately but receives sauce over the dish. The ticket confirms the separate-sauce request. The kitchen offers a remake in eight minutes; no price adjustment is approved.

Role A: Server: apologize, describe the remake option, and check the guest's choice.

Role B: Guest: you want the correct dish but need to know the wait.

Possible opening: I asked for the sauce on the side; this plate has it on top.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the ticketed request.
- Distinguish an available option from a started remake.
- Confirm the guest's choice before reporting it to the kitchen.

Add a complication: The guest asks whether the remake is already being prepared, but you haven't requested it yet.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining and splitting a bill

Distinguish equal payment shares from item-based bills.

CASE

Three diners have a fictional \$72 total with all listed charges included. They request 'three ways': this could mean equal payments or separate checks by item. The restaurant supports either before payment. Ask which they mean; equal shares would be \$24.

Teach this move

'Three ways' doesn't identify a division method. Confirm the method and visible charges before presenting the payment request; never ask learners to handle card credentials.

Vocabulary to check: itemized bill, split payment, separate checks, service charge.

Model response

When you say three ways, would you like three equal payments or separate checks for each person's items? The total shown is seventy-two dollars, including the listed charges. Equal payments would be twenty-four dollars each. If you prefer separate checks, I'll confirm who had each item before any payment is taken.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question avoids deciding a financial preference for the diners.

Second-round challenge

The guests disagree over the shared dessert. Ask for their agreed allocation rather than choose for them.

Language-check answers

1. D - separate checks by item Correct. Items are assigned to the person paying for them.
2. A - twenty-four dollars Correct. Three equal shares of 72 are 24.

05 • Conversations

1. Three ways can mean two things - The \$72 bill in the case is unpaid.
2. A charge appears twice - A guest queries a duplicate drink on an unpaid bill.
3. An optional extra is not required - A server explains a fictional bill with a labeled service charge.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two payers, four diners

Four diners agree that one payer covers all food and another covers all drinks. The bill is unpaid and can be split by item.

Role A: Server: clarify the two groups of charges.

Role B: Guest: you pay for food, including the shared dessert; your companion covers drinks.

Possible opening: Would you like the food on one check and the drinks on the other?

Success checks

- Resolve the conflicting descriptions.
- Place dessert with food.
- Confirm the grouping before payment.

Add a complication: The guest initially says 'half each' but then explains the unequal item grouping.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Agreeing on clearing and shared service

Get permission to clear specific items without rushing the table.

CASE

At table 2, one diner's plate is empty but the shared vegetable dish still has food. The diner is using the plate for another portion. Ask what can be cleared; offer extra sharing plates without removing active items.

Teach this move

An empty plate may still be in use. Use 'finished with' for an object; 'finished eating' asks about the person's meal.

Vocabulary to check: pre-bus, place setting, sharing plate, crumb.

Model response

May I clear the empty glasses, or are you still using them? I'll leave your plate and the shared vegetables because you're taking another portion. Would an extra sharing plate help? I can bring one and then check which serving items you're finished with, without interrupting the rest of your meal.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. A specific, neutral choice avoids pressure to finish.

Second-round challenge

The guest says 'take those' while pointing between glasses and plates. Clarify the items.

Language-check answers

1. B - leave it here Correct. Leaving it respects the guest's stated use.
2. C - with Correct. 'Finished with' means no longer using something.

05 • Conversations

1. An empty plate still has a purpose - Table 2 has a shared vegetable dish, as in the case.
2. Reaching across a conversation - A server needs permission to retrieve a dish near a guest.
3. Enough settings for a shared dessert - Two diners want one dessert but separate spoons and plates.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A guest steps away

A guest leaves the table briefly. Their companion says the main plate is still in use, but the starter plate is finished.

Role A: Server: confirm which plate can be cleared.

Role B: Companion: identify the small starter plate and ask that the main stay.

Possible opening: Which plate has your companion finished with?

Success checks

- Identify the small starter plate.
- Leave the main in place.
- Avoid inferring that the absent guest has finished.

Add a complication: Both plates contain scraps, so appearance alone does not resolve the question.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handing over a live section

Name each table's status and get the incoming server's acknowledgment.

CASE

At 8:00 Maya takes over tables 4 and 5. Table 4's mains are served, and dessert has not been ordered. Table 5 has an open check and a pending duplicate-coffee query being reviewed by the shift lead. Ask Maya to accept both follow-ups.

Teach this move

Separate an open question from a completed action. A handover needs a receiver, not merely a note left at the station.

Vocabulary to check: section, open check, side work, handover.

Model response

Maya, table four has its mains and hasn't ordered dessert. Table five's check is still open because the shift lead is reviewing a possible duplicate coffee charge. Please check on four's dessert preference and get the lead's decision before presenting five's bill again. Can you take those two follow-ups while I finish the station restock?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The incoming server knows what remains to do.

Second-round challenge

The shift lead has not decided about the coffee charge. Keep the question open while accepting follow-up.

Language-check answers

1. B - open Correct. An open check remains outstanding.
2. D - I will check with table four Correct. Maya explicitly accepts the named table follow-up.

05 • Conversations

1. Two tables, two different loose ends - The 8:00 handover in the case.
2. A break handover includes the limit - A server asks a colleague to cover one table during a short break.
3. Restocking without an assumption - Two servers divide closing support work while one table remains seated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A move between sections

Table 9 moves to table 19 for a quieter seat. The same unpaid order must follow the diners. The incoming server has not been briefed.

Role A: Outgoing server: explain the move and current order.

Role B: Incoming server: accept the diners at 19; their drinks have arrived and mains are pending.

Possible opening: The guests at nineteen moved from nine; they haven't placed a second order.

Success checks

- Identify old and new tables.
- Avoid duplicating the order.
- Confirm who tells the runner and follows up on the mains.

Add a complication: A runner still sees table 9 on the food ticket.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All people, prices, policies, counts, and incidents are fictional language practice, not food-safety, allergy, alcohol-service, legal, or payment-processing training. Follow workplace training and local requirements. Ingredient and cross-contact questions need the designated kitchen lead; do not guarantee suitability. This course concerns table service, not restaurant management.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/waiters-and-waitresses.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Waiters and Waitresses

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-3031.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.